Middle East Technical University
Department of Electrical and Electronics Engineering

EE201 – Circuit Theory I

Lecture 9: Trees, Cutsets and Fundamental Loops

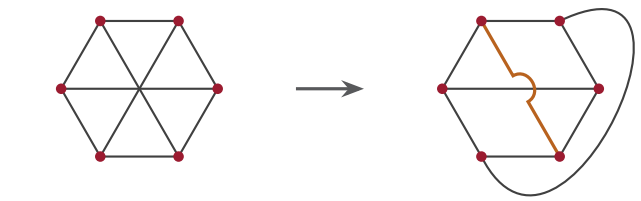
M. Mert Ankaralı

Colour code used in these notes and in the slides

current i | voltage v, cutsets, loops | tree branches | nodes ①

1. Beyond planar graphs

Meshes need a drawing with no crossings. A nonplanar graph has no such drawing, so it has no meshes and no mesh matrix. In the hexagon below, the three diagonals cross at the centre. Moving one diagonal outside removes one crossing, but a jumper wire (a hop) is still needed.



crossings at the centre jumper wire: still one hop

How do we then find $n-1$ independent KCL and $b-n+1$ independent KVL equations? This lecture gives a method that needs no planar drawing and works for **any connected graph**.

2. Trees

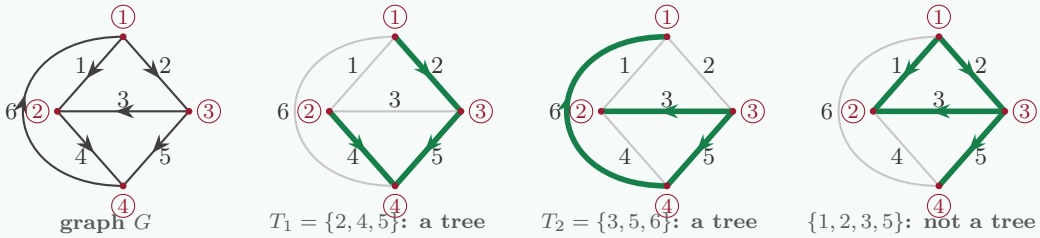
Tree

Let G be a connected graph. A subgraph T of G is a **tree** if

1. T contains all the nodes of G,
2. T is connected, and
3. T contains no loops.

Example 9.1 — trees of the bridge graph

Which of the green subgraphs are trees?



T_1 and T_2 reach all four nodes, are connected and have no loop. The set $\{1,2,3,5\}$ contains the loop of branches 1, 2, 3, so it is not a tree. A graph has many trees.

A tree has $n-1$ branches

Build the tree one branch at a time, starting from a single node. Each new branch must reach a new node: a branch between two nodes already reached would close a loop. All n nodes must be reached, so the tree has exactly $n-1$ branches. The other $b-n+1$ branches are left out.

3. Cutsets

Cutset

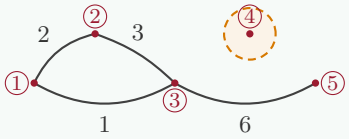
Let G be a connected graph. A set C of branches is a **cutset** if

1. removing all the branches of C leaves the graph unconnected, and
2. removing all the branches of C except any one of them leaves it connected.

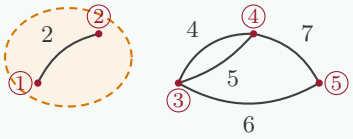
The second condition makes the cutset minimal: every branch in it is needed. Minimal does not mean fewest branches; cutsets of the same graph can have different sizes.

Example 9.2 — cutsets of a figure-eight graph

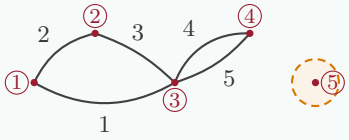
In each panel the removed branches are deleted; look at what is left.



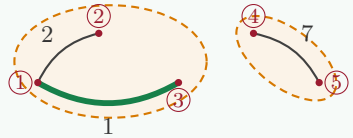
$C_1 = \{4, 5, 7\}$: node ④ cut off



$C_2 = \{1, 3\}$: nodes ①, ② cut off



$C_3 = \{6, 7\}$: node ⑤ cut off



$\{1, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$ with 1 put back: still two pieces

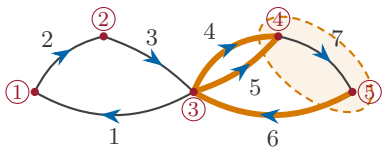
For C_1: removing branches 4, 5, 7 cuts off node ④, so condition 1 holds. Putting back any one of them reaches node ④ again, so condition 2 holds. C_2 and C_3 are checked the same way. With all branches back, the dashed closed surface around the cut-off piece crosses exactly the branches of the cutset.

The set $\{1, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$ is *not* a cutset. Removing it leaves three pieces. With branch 1 put back, the graph is still unconnected, so condition 2 fails. Branches 1 and 3 are not needed: $\{4, 5, 6\}$ alone is a cutset.

The set $\{4, 6\}$ is not a cutset either, but for the opposite reason. Removing it leaves the graph connected, since branch 5 still joins nodes ③ and ④, so condition 1 fails. Branches 4 and 5 are parallel: both join ③ and ④. A closed surface that crosses one of them crosses the other too. So parallel branches are in a cutset together or not at all.

KCL on a cutset. A cutset splits the graph into two parts. A closed surface around one part crosses exactly the branches of the cutset. So by KCL on that closed surface, the currents of the cutset branches add up to zero (each with + if it leaves the surface, − if it enters).

Take the branch currents below, in the arrow directions. They satisfy KCL at every node. Consider the cutset $\{4, 5, 6\}$, with the surface around nodes ④ and ⑤.



branch	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
current (A)	2	2	2	1	2	3	3

Current i_6 leaves the surface; i_4 and i_5 enter it:

$$i_6 - i_4 - i_5 = 3 - 1 - 2 = 0.$$

This is the sum of KCL at nodes ④ and ⑤: $(i_7 - i_4 - i_5) + (i_6 - i_7) = 0$. The current i_7 is inside the surface and cancels.

4. Fundamental cutsets

Fix a tree T of a connected graph G. The branches of G that are not in T form the **co-tree**. Now pick one tree branch β and remove it. The tree falls into two parts. The branches of G that join these two parts form a cutset.

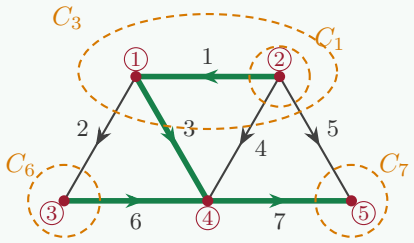
Fundamental cutset

The **fundamental cutset** of a tree branch β is β together with the co-tree branches that join the two parts of the tree. It contains exactly one tree branch, β. Its direction is taken as the direction of β.

It has only one tree branch: every other tree branch lies inside one of the two parts, so it does not join them. For the direction, draw the closed surface around one part. If β leaves the surface, the cutset points out of the surface; if β enters, it points in. In KCL a branch counts $+$ if it crosses the surface the same way as β, and $-$ otherwise.

Example 9.3 — fundamental cutsets and KCL

The graph G has $n = 5$ nodes and $b = 7$ branches. Take the tree $\{1, 3, 6, 7\}$ (green, $n - 1 = 4$ branches). The co-tree is $\{2, 4, 5\}$ ($b - n + 1 = 3$ branches).



tree br.	cutset	KCL
1	$\{1, 4, 5\}$	$i_1 + i_4 + i_5 = 0$
3	$\{3, 2, 4, 5\}$	$i_3 + i_2 + i_4 + i_5 = 0$
6	$\{6, 2\}$	$i_6 - i_2 = 0$
7	$\{7, 5\}$	$i_7 + i_5 = 0$

Each surface encloses one of the two parts left after removing a tree branch. For C_3: removing branch 3 leaves the parts $\{①, ②\}$ and $\{③, ④, ⑤\}$. Branches 3, 2, 4, 5 join them, and all four go from the upper part to the lower part, the same way as branch 3: every term has $+$.

KCL on the fundamental cutsets

A tree gives $n - 1$ fundamental cutsets, so $n - 1$ KCL equations. They are independent: each equation contains its own tree branch current, which appears in no other equation.

Remark. Each equation has one tree branch current. So once the co-tree branch currents are known, the tree branch currents follow. For G:

$$i_1 = -i_4 - i_5, \quad i_3 = -i_2 - i_4 - i_5, \quad i_6 = i_2, \quad i_7 = -i_5.$$

5. Fundamental loops

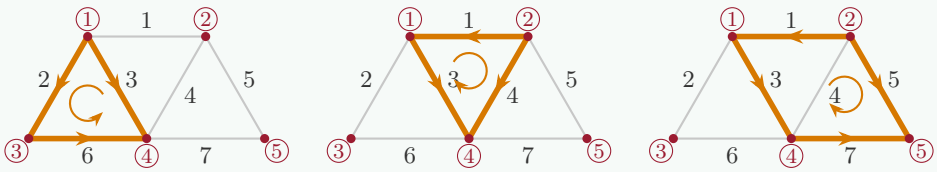
Fundamental loop

Let T be a tree of a connected graph G. Each co-tree branch defines exactly one loop that contains that co-tree branch and no other co-tree branch. It is the **fundamental loop** of that co-tree branch. Its direction is taken as the direction of the co-tree branch.

Adding one co-tree branch to the tree closes exactly one loop: the co-tree branch plus the tree path between its two ends.

Example 9.4 — fundamental loops and KVL

Same graph and tree as in Example 9.3. Each co-tree branch closes one loop. Walk it in the direction of its co-tree branch: a branch voltage counts + if its arrow points along the walk, − if against.



loop of 2: $\{2,6,3\}$ $v_2 + v_6 - v_3 = 0$

loop of 4: $\{4,3,1\}$ $v_4 - v_3 - v_1 = 0$

loop of 5: $\{5,7,3,1\}$ $v_5 - v_7 - v_3 - v_1 = 0$

KVL on the fundamental loops

A tree gives $b-n+1$ fundamental loops, so $b-n+1$ KVL equations. They are independent: each equation contains its own co-tree branch voltage, which appears in no other equation.

Remark. Each equation has one co-tree branch voltage. So once the tree branch voltages are known, the co-tree branch voltages follow. For G:

$$v_2 = v_3 - v_6, \quad v_4 = v_1 + v_3, \quad v_5 = v_1 + v_3 + v_7.$$

6. Any connected graph

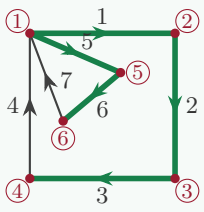
The tree is the key, and every connected graph has one. So:

	how many	gives
tree branches	$n-1$	fundamental cutsets: the $n-1$ KCL equations
co-tree branches	$b-n+1$	fundamental loops: the $b-n+1$ KVL equations

No drawing is needed. This works for nonplanar graphs, and it is also the fix for separable graphs met earlier.

Example 9.5 — the separable graph

The square with the triangle inside, joined only at node ①: $n = 6$, $b = 7$. Take the tree $\{1,2,3,5,6\}$ (green, $n-1=5$). The co-tree is $\{4,7\}$ ($b-n+1=2$).



tree br.	cutset	KCL
1	$\{1,4\}$	$i_1 - i_4 = 0$
2	$\{2,4\}$	$i_2 - i_4 = 0$
3	$\{3,4\}$	$i_3 - i_4 = 0$
5	$\{5,7\}$	$i_5 - i_7 = 0$
6	$\{6,7\}$	$i_6 - i_7 = 0$

co-tree br.	KVL on its loop
4	$v_4 + v_1 + v_2 + v_3 = 0$
7	$v_7 + v_5 + v_6 = 0$

The two fundamental loops are the square and the triangle, each a single loop. The KCL equations give $i_1 = i_2 = i_3 = i_4$ and $i_5 = i_6 = i_7$: one current for the square and one for the triangle. In total $5 + 2 = 7 = b$ independent equations. Node ① causes no trouble.

7. Looking ahead

Node voltages and mesh currents were good unknowns: few, and one law held automatically. Trees give the general version. The $n-1$ **tree branch voltages** fix every branch voltage, like node voltages. The $b-n+1$ **co-tree branch currents** fix every branch current, like mesh currents. Both work for any connected graph.

Summary

- A **tree** of a connected graph contains all nodes, is connected and has no loop. It has $n-1$ branches; the other $b-n+1$ form the **co-tree**.
- A **cutset** is a minimal set of branches whose removal cuts the graph in two. KCL holds on every cutset: it is KCL on a closed surface.
- Each tree branch has a **fundamental cutset**: it and some co-tree branches. These give $n-1$ independent KCL equations. Co-tree currents fix the tree currents.
- Each co-tree branch has a **fundamental loop**: it and a tree path. These give $b-n+1$ independent KVL equations. Tree voltages fix the co-tree voltages.
- No drawing is needed: this works for any connected graph, planar or not, separable or not.

Reading

- Chua, Desoer & Kuh, *Linear and Nonlinear Circuits* — trees, cutsets and fundamental loops.
- Lecture notes and videos of Prof. Emre Tuna, `users.metu.edu.tr/etuna/ee201` — notes pp. 17–18; Lecture 8 video: nonplanar circuits 15:51, tree 16:10, example 18:01, cutset 22:33, example 25:32, fundamental cutset 30:35, example and co-tree 32:55, KCL on fundamental cutsets 38:32, remark on co-tree currents 41:48, fundamental loop 43:51, example 47:07, remark on tree voltages 55:38.